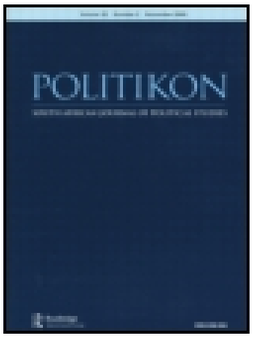

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What Would the Decolonisation of a Political Science Curriculum Entail? Lessons to be Learnt From the East African Experience at the Federal University of East Africa

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ABSTRACT
The #FeesMustFall Movement in 2015 invoked old calls for free education, decolonization and Africanisation of the curriculum, which have deep roots in African political history. From the 1920s, Africans expressed utmost discomfort about the fact that their education systems had been relegated to the periphery and replaced by Western education systems. The school curriculum did not resonate with the reality on the ground and university colleges taught a foreign curriculum. At independence in the 1960s, African countries engaged in intense debates regarding the decolonisation and Africanisation of the curriculum at national universities. Against this backdrop, in this article, we look at Political Science as an academic discipline and extrapolate what it would entail to decolonise and Africanise its curriculum. Using the experiences at the Federal University of East Africa as a reference point, we conclude that the task is not insurmountable and propose a vanguard approach in making this happen.

Introduction

The historic 1884–1885 Berlin Conference which formally authorised the carving of the African continent into little compartments called 'colonies' marked a new epoch in Africa's political history. In essence, colonialism was primarily predicated on the power dynamics between Africans and their European counterparts. Power, in this case, included both *hard power* (which involved the use of military force) and *soft power* (which included the ability to convince others or entice them financially and materially to buy into an alien idea). In other instances, 'smart power' which combined the two was also resorted to (Heywood 2013). As many European countries exercised power over African countries, the latter were obliged to do things they did not necessarily embrace, simply because they had made vain attempts to ward off colonial encroachment. The school and, later, the university curriculum became one site of the struggle. Both levels experienced unprecedented indoctrination of black students, which induced them not only to despise their cultural bringing but also to ensure their docility and subsequent vulnerability to manipulation by white people. The content of what was taught at academic institutions placed Europeans at the centre while simultaneously relegating Africans to the periphery. Everything that Africans had previously done in terms of educating their children was completely wiped out under the pretext of 'civilisation' and 'modernisation'. Even the experience

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obtained from pre-colonial African universities which existed in West and North Africa (Mngomezulu 2012) was not considered at best and was obliterated at worst. This ploy continued unabated throughout the colonial period until the dawn of democracy in the 1960s and 1970s.

In this article, we discuss the issue of curriculum changes in Political Science with specific reference to tertiary education, which is where Political Science is taught as an academic discipline. The change we refer to is the decolonisation and Africanisation of the curriculum so that it could speak to the local (African) context and address African problems in line with the African Union (AU) principles. We argue that Political Science could have been taught differently, drawing from African experiences instead of drawing examples from Europe and America. Given that Africa has now been liberated from the yoke of colonial oppression, our contention is that it is possible to decolonise and Africanise this discipline without compromising the much revered academic standards. We argue that this goal could be achieved without weakening the discipline's stature – after all, African and Africanist scholars are the authors of some of the Political Science books used at tertiary institutions. We move from the premise that pre-colonial Africans made a significant contribution to modern civilisation in all spheres of life, including education (Njoh 2006).

Not surprisingly, the University Colleges which were established during the colonial period tended to privilege a foreign curriculum for reasons outlined below. Consequently, African students were taught things that did not resonate with their immediate environment. Even if they wanted to change the status quo, they simply could not because the power dynamics were skewed in favour of their European counterparts. At independence, both the political and academic African leadership called for the reconfiguration of the entire educational landscape. This included calls for curriculum reforms to reflect the changed political environment. We are cognisant and mindful of the fact that even in apartheid South Africa, attempts were made by scholars like the late Archie Mafeje, who in 1968 engaged in robust debates about the need for curriculum reforms. We also have a good grip on the history of university education in Africa, as discussed in detail in Mngomezulu (2004, 2012).

However, in this article, we both deliberately and consciously use East Africa as an example to explicate some of the arguments advanced in the article. We do this not only to learn from history but also to envision how a Political Science curriculum could be decolonised and Africanised along the lines proposed by the political and academic leadership in East Africa in the 1960s. This fits neatly within the Mafeje debates of the 1960s (Mafeje 2011). We should briskly state upfront that our usage of East Africa as an example should not be misconstrued to mean that this was the only site of the struggle, nor should it be misinterpreted to mean that the proposals we proffer later in this article are applicable only to certain parts of the African continent. Our focus is on the decolonisation of the curriculum of the Political Science discipline with the view to give it an African outlook compared to what has been taught traditionally, which placed Europe and America at the centre of the discussion and ignored African tradition and the African context. While East Africa is our focal point, we still draw examples from other parts of Africa and locate the article to the broader African context – both in terms of time and geographical location of the debates referred to in the article.

We should briskly state that from an analytical point of view, we are mindful of the fact that decolonisation and Africanisation do not necessarily mean one and the same thing. However, we note that these concepts are related as evidenced in the literature (Mngomezulu 2017; Ndofirepi, Mngomezulu, and Cross 2017). The areas in which we focus include: research topics, research methods, as well as the actual content of what is taught to the students. We tantalisingly bring into the equation students and academic staff because they represent those who should be taught the changed curriculum as well as those who would be saddled with the responsibility to teach it. Our view is that for the change of the curriculum to materialise, this would need a change of mindset not just by the authors of Political Science books but also by both students and staff.

Structurally, we begin this article by defining the key concepts and link them to the main discussion. This is done with the view of ensuring that there is no ambiguity in understanding the concepts in the context of this article. Secondly, we remind the reader that the debate about the need for curriculum changes is not new in Africa and that there is an epistemology which explains it. Previous calls were made across the continent in the 1960s – in both East Africa and elsewhere on the African continent. Thirdly, we discuss the role played by colonialism in changing the African education curriculum in general and that of Political Science in particular. Fourthly and lastly, we offer some ideas on what the process of decolonising the Political Science curriculum would entail, drawing from the East African experience. This is accordingly followed by our concluding remarks and recommendations.

Conceptual definitions and their relevance to the discussion

Conceptual definitions are important in research for several reasons, the most important of which is that at times one concept has different meanings. To avoid ambiguity, it becomes critical to provide a contextual understanding of each key concept. This ensures that both the author and the reader see things from the same vintage point or have the same understanding of what the concept means in the context of the document. It is against this backdrop that in this section we define the key concepts used in the article and link them to the discussion.

Africanisation

This concept (and decolonisation) has been problematised by authors such as Metz (2015). We are also acutely aware of the fact that some renowned authors such as Frantz Fanon hold critical views about this concept but we believe that it is worth using and therefore defining to benefit the discussion. The concept is sometimes erroneously used interchangeably with 'decolonisation'. It means the process of making something African, e.g. juxtaposing an 'African' and a 'European' curriculum. Other scholars have argued that the concept refers to 'the process of becoming or making something African or have African features' (Ndofirepi, Mngomezulu, and Cross 2017, 49). Those who embrace this concept understand it to denote *exclusion* of that which is not African. While this viewpoint cannot be totally dismissed, there are authors who advance the view that Africanisation is not an exclusive concept. Conversely, they define it to mean 'a process of *inclusion* that stresses the importance of affirming African cultures and identities in a world community' (Makgoba 1997, 1). In essence, as Ramose (1998) avers, in the

worldview of Africanisation, the African experience does not only constitute the foundation of all forms of knowledge, important as that might be. On the contrary, it is the source for the construction of such knowledge. Thus, Africanisation puts African-produced knowledge first without necessarily dismissing other sources of knowledge. When we talk about the Africanisation of the curriculum, we mean making the curriculum resonate with the African context as opposed to showing tenets of foreign influence and/or dominance. An Africanised curriculum places the African knowledge system at the epicentre in the same manner that a Europeanised curriculum would place the European knowledge system at the core of any teaching and research.

Curriculum

The word 'curriculum' has been theorised and conceptualised in many ways, over time and across the globe. Authors such as Beauchamp (1992) as well as Ornstein and Hunkins (2016) are among such authors. Discussions on curriculum matters and African thought systems as they apply to decolonising epistemologies on Africa include but are not limited to the works of authors and philosophers like Mudimbe (1988), Ake (1979), Mafeje (2011), Mbembe (2015) and Gordon (2000). However, while these and many other sources are useful in terms of helping us have a nuanced understanding of curriculum, it is not our intention to dwell much on the epistemological discussions they engage in. Ours is simply to note their contribution so that when readers think about the decolonisation and Africanisation of the curriculum, they can reflect on the theoretical arguments advanced by these authors.

This concept means different things to different people, including academics. For some, curriculum refers to the *content* that is taught to students. At another level, it is understood to mean a set of *subjects* that are taught at an academic institution. Others define it in a positive manner, while others attach negative connotations to it. For example, Kelly (1999, 83) defines curriculum as 'a syllabus which may limit the planning of teachers to a consideration of the content or the body of knowledge they wish to transmit or a list of the subjects to be taught or both.' This view of the curriculum means that it is a bad thing to have. In contrast to this, the *Hong Kong Year Book* (2006) perceives curriculum in a positive light, arguing that it could achieve the objective of motivating learning, enhancing knowledge and abilities, and developing positive values or, at times, attitudes.

All these definitions are useful in their own right. Put simply, curriculum is a planned outcome (Morris and Adamson 2010). It refers to *that* which is being taught, while 'method' refers to *how* it is taught. It is the content that goes into teaching (and research). Therefore, when we talk about a Political Science curriculum, we simply mean the content of what goes into the teaching and research of that academic discipline at institutions of higher learning and how such content is taught to political science students.

Decolonisation

As with Africanisation, calls for the decolonisation of the curriculum are not new in Africa. Debates on this concept abound (Metz 2015; Heleta 2016). Time and space will not allow us to dwell on these debates. Ours is simply to show its complexity. Therefore, finding a universal definition of the term 'decolonisation' is difficult (if not impossible). This is so

because people attach different connotations to it – some of which are context-specific. In one sense, 'decolonisation' refers to the process of removing the colonial element(s) from an institution such as government or academic institutions. For some, decolonisation means ridding the mind of any colonial elements. This is what Ngugi wa Thiong'o had in mind when he wrote his influential book titled: *Decolonising the Mind* (1986). Within the same context, decolonising the curriculum in the African context means ridding such a curriculum of any colonial elements so that it reflects African value systems and draws from these values to nurture the youth and society. In wa Thiong'o's view, decolonisation has global connotations. He corroborates Fanon's view that decolonisation is a radical process in which the oppressed classes of subalternity all over the world would have to 'adopt a scientific materialistic world outlook on nature, human society and human thought' (Wa Thiong'o 1981, 31). This projects decolonisation as something achievable, albeit with difficulties and challenges.

In the decolonisation agenda, the first logical step would be to replace the colonial elements with something indigenous or local. In the context of the curriculum, decolonisation means removing colonial elements from the curriculum and replacing them with African elements. In that sense, decolonisation and Africanisation are closely related concepts even though they do not necessarily mean one and the same thing – they both focus on making colonialism dispensable and replacing it with indigenous knowledge systems. Both concepts espouse the view that indigeneity should take precedence over anything foreign to Africa without closing the doors to the latter. Decolonising the curriculum falls within this realm of thinking.

Knowledge production

As a general norm, the term 'knowledge' signifies 'all forms of information production including those involved in technological innovation, cultural creativity and academic advance' (Pollock 2009, 1). When scanning dictionary meanings, we realise that knowledge is sometimes defined as 'fact' or 'practical know-how'. Some even perceive knowledge as 'truth' (Starbuck 2009). Drawing from this noun, we then talk about the production of such knowledge – what we refer to as 'knowledge production'.

In a nutshell, 'knowledge production' refers to how knowledge is generated or produced. This concept is predicated on the understanding that there are different ways of producing knowledge, including research and experimentation. Knowledge derives from different sources (Cohen and Laporte 2004). In pre-colonial Africa, knowledge was produced and preserved orally. Folktales, idioms, proverbs, legends and such related practices were some of the forms of knowledge production used by Africans. With the advent of Christianity and colonialism, knowledge production and preservation took a different approach. It was now produced and preserved in written format. The common denominator was that in both periods the aim was not just to produce knowledge for its own sake. On the contrary, knowledge was produced and preserved for its utility in impacting people's lives.

Power

Power dictates who has control. Michel Foucault sees a relationship between power and knowledge and argues that the two concepts interrelate in order to (re)produce one

another (Gordon 1980). This knowledge production has power dynamics in the sense that power privileges some forms of knowledge. Similarly, knowledge reifies power. Therefore, the colonial state used power (both military and economic/financial) to shape curricula in higher education (Ozawa 2009). At independence, the post-colonial state inherited that power and did what the colonial state had done. In response, academics called for academic freedom and university autonomy, thereby contesting this power. Students too derived power from protest to call for change. Therefore, it would be foolhardy to try and discuss curriculum changes without infusing power into the discussion.

We share Pallaver's (2011) view that power is one of the most central and yet problematic concepts in international relations. This is so because the word 'power' can be understood in different contexts. In one sense, it means the ability to do something. In another sense, it refers to having an edge over another person. Thus, March (1966) was justified in concluding that on the whole, power is a disappointing concept. However, this does not mean that we can easily discard this concept due to the fact that it is disappointing.

Some people have power while others do not. Invariably, those who have the power are able to dictate the terms of engagement or interaction. In other words, they dominate in whatever is being done and determine the outcome by virtue of the fact that they have the power to do so. By contrast, those who do not have power cannot dictate the terms of engagement. Equally, those who have little power have little dominance. If we link this concept to curriculum changes, we could say that those who have the power decide the nature of the curriculum that will be taught at academic institutions such as universities.

Debates about the Africanisation and decolonisation of the curriculum

As mentioned earlier, debates about the need to Africanise and decolonise the curriculum at tertiary institutions is not new in Africa (Gordon 2000; Mafeje 2011; Mbembe 2015). The same call was made in the 1960s and has not stopped to-date. There is a general consensus in academia that the question of decolonisation within the African continent continues to draw a great deal of attention (Kebede 2004). One observation is that 'decolonisation as a topic in literary and cultural studies has always generated a tremendous amount of argument' (Osha and Muchie n.d.). What the #FeesMustFall Movement did in 2015 was to reiterate a point already made by students in the 1960s and 1970s. This was the case, for example, with what was dubbed 'The Akivanga Crisis' at the University of Dar es Salaam. Following the World Bank's introduction of the Structural Adjustment Programmes (SAPs) in the 1980s, students were forced to pay fees and they resisted (Coffentzis 2000; 2010; Federici, Caffentzis, and Alidou 2000).

The call for the decolonisation and Africanisation of the curriculum in Africa predates the independence euphoria which took shape after 1945. Regarding decolonisation of the curriculum, while it would be erroneous to insinuate that there was no such call during the colonial period, the reality is that the call became even louder following the attainment of political independence and the establishment of national universities. In the context of East Africa, this call was even louder following the disbandment of the Federal University of East Africa in 1970 and the establishment of national universities (Mngomezulu 2004, 2012).

It should not come as a surprise that the clarion call for the Africanisation and decolonisation of the curriculum has been so relentless for decades. This is so because, by its very nature, 'African higher education is irrefutably a much debated phenomenon (Ndofirepi, Mngomezulu, and Cross 2017, 48). Looking at the two concepts from a curriculum perspective, Dowling and Seepe (2004) make reference to what they call 'a response curriculum'. Implicit here is the view that an African academic institution such as a university should always strive to teach an Africanised curriculum which resonates with the local situation. It must be responsive to the immediate needs of the society it serves before being relevant to the wider society elsewhere.

When deliberating on curriculum issues in the context of Africa, one cannot escape reflecting on these concepts. Part of the reason is that by its very nature, a university as an academic institution has multiple identities with both local and international dimensions (Mngomezulu 2012). This is not only applicable to African higher education per se. In her study of Asian and Pacific countries, Knight and De Wit (1997) came to the same conclusion that the status of an academic institution such as a university is ever contested. Thus, Africanisation and decolonisation continue to be juxtaposed with internationalisation and globalisation. The curriculum cannot be immune to these debates.

The impact of colonialism on the African curriculum

Here, the notion of power as defined above and as conceived by Foucault is relevant. Power dynamics played themselves out on curriculum matters. Colonialism and Christianity used power to impose the curriculum on Africans. These two left an indelible mark on the African education system in general and that of African institutions of higher learning in particular. With regard to the former, Africa's informal education system (which was based on oral tradition) was undermined and suppressed through power. Any form of political education which had been taught through different avenues such as oral tradition, folktales and legends was consciously discouraged and denied space to operate from. Instead, Western notions of teaching, research and overall learning were imposed as power dynamics that were at play.

The same thing happened with regard to African institutions of higher learning; they were undermined in many respects – including issues of curriculum changes. This change was occasioned by a confluence of factors. Among them was the very fact that most African higher education institutions emerged from the Western culture and tradition (Ajayi et al. 1996; Altbatch and Knight 2007). Those that predate the colonial era and are older than most renowned British universities such as the universities of Cambridge and Oxford in Britain (Mngomezulu 2012) had their institutional culture completely eroded as a result of the collaboration between Christianity on the one hand and colonialism on the other (Gray 1982). At these African universities, the institutional physical infrastructure, staff profile, research agenda and research topics all replicated what obtained at Western institutions of higher learning. This untenable situation meant that subjects like Political Science, history, economics, religion and geography were taught from a Eurocentric point of view with no resonance to the local environment.

As a consequence of these developments, the African child was exposed to European history and politics, not their local (African) histories and politics. At the tertiary level, subjects like Political Science were taught from a European perspective. Within this context,

themes such as democracy, leadership, state formation, nation, society and administration were discussed as though they only applied to the European context. The collective decision-making practice, conflict resolution mechanisms, sophisticated governance and economic systems of the African people were all removed from both Political Science and history books. Africans were portrayed as people who owed their entire existence to their white counterparts. This situation continued until the demise of colonialism, which saw Africans taking charge of their political and governance systems using the political power accorded by independence.

At independence, African national universities fell under the control of the new political leadership who used their power to determine the university curriculum. The power struggle between the latter and the academic leadership invoked concepts like 'academic freedom' and 'university autonomy'. This intra-African power struggle continued until the 1980s.

From the 1980s, International Financial Institutions (IFIs) such as the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund (IMF) entered the terrain and claimed some of the power. National governments lost their power as the World Bank introduced SAPs, which dictated to African governments what to do and how. The allocation of funds to tertiary institutions was henceforth determined by the World Bank. This included staff salaries. In the same vein, the curriculum was also largely dictated by the World Bank and other donors. The African political and academic leadership lost power to determine the fate of their institutions (Coffentzis, 2000; 2010; Federici, Caffentzis, and Alidou 2000). This created enmity between them and the students (Zeilig and Dawson 2008).

Within this context, Africans found themselves tied up to Western notions of university education. Consequently, the university curriculum did not speak to the local needs and situations anymore. Instead of becoming 'African universities', these institutions became European universities physically located in Africa. Noticeably, some of the Africans who had studied at these Eurocentric and missionary-oriented institutions became the early agents of change in their respective countries. They had studied at Western universities where they were exposed to different political ideas. On their return, they joined hands with the political leadership and questioned the curriculum that was taught at African universities. They were not impressed by its European leanings. Thus, they started blaming expatriate staff based at African universities and pressurised them to either switch over from the Eurocentric curriculum and embrace an Afrocentric one or simply leave their jobs as university lecturers to pave the way for African academics. This is what happened in East Africa (East Africa High Commission 1961; Rubadiri 1964; Kenya National Archives, KA/2/17). This call was necessitated by the realisation that African politics, values and many other aspects of life were all fading away and were being eroded. This was because the expatriate staff became the agents of entrenching and promoting a Westernised curriculum.

When concerns were raised by some expatriate staff and some East African political and academic leadership that the Africanisation project would weaken the status of academic institutions because East Africans were not ready to take the lead, other East Africans advanced a different view. Addressing the East Africa High Commission, Wilberforce Ndiope, a Member of this structure, raised concerns that Africanization was moving at a snail's pace and called for the acceleration of the process. He intimated that

> I am sure, Mr. Speaker, that Africans will never learn any business or take up responsible posts unless they are tried out. We have got several Africans who are capable of doing the job but they not being given a chance. It is no good trying to say we can learn to swim by looking at the water. (East Africa High Commission 1961)

The Africanisation of staff in East Africa continued to be the subject for debate at the Constituent Colleges of the Federal University and during inter-territorial meetings in regional (East African) structures. For example, during the Council meeting held at Makerere College on 2 August 1963, several decisions were made. Among them were the following: (i) Council fully accepted the necessity and desirability on social and academic grounds of a rapid rate of East Africanisation and considered that this could be achieved more expeditiously; (ii) East Africanisation had to be assumed to refer to the appointment of persons holding citizenship of East African countries; (iii) In making steps to maintain an increase in the rate of East Africanisation, it was decided that everything should be done to ensure that attempts in this direction should not only be made, but should be seen to be made; and (iv) It was decided that it should always be borne in mind as a primary consideration that in the interests of East Africa the high standards which had been built up had to be maintained (Minutes of the 69th meeting of the Makerere College Council 1963).

Before this meeting, the Academic Board at Makerere College had taken a decision to recommend that the College Council should recommend: (i) That every effort be made to accelerate the rate of East-Africanisation in the College staff at all levels and in all functions; (ii) That in instances where it is unlikely that candidates with suitable qualifications will present themselves, earnest consideration be given to the preparation of East African candidates by further study, courses of training, in-service training or any other means; and (iii) That in advertising any vacant posts, special consideration be given to East African candidates (University of Nairobi Archives, PUEA/12/18). As more and more Africans authored books in various subjects, the European (expatriate) staff became dispensable. The fact that African countries had obtained political freedom meant that they could now have a say and power in the curriculum that was taught at national universities. Thus, subjects like political science, history, literature, sociology, archaeology, medicine and many others were now approached from an African perspective, not from a Eurocentric perspective as had been the case before (Okelo 1965; Olembo 1968).

Gradually, the impact of colonialism dwindled as Africans took charge of their fate and at times deployed administrators and lecturers at these institutions to ensure that any vestiges of colonialism were obliterated. The Africanised curriculum was embraced – although some African scholars still privileged the Western curriculum. Our discussion in this article is meant to continue these debates.

As implied above, the reconfiguration of the curriculum was not without challenges. Mngomezulu (2012) recalls that political scientists like the late Ali Mazrui faced serious challenges from the political leadership when trying to decolonise and Africanise the political science curriculum at Makerere. President Milton Obote of Uganda asked Professor Mazrui if he was a 'political scientist' or a 'politician'. This was after Mazrui had become critical of Obote's government and infused discussions about it in the Political Science curriculum to explain Western notions of authoritarian rule, maladministration, undemocratic rule, state failure, nepotism and kleptocracy. Such behaviour by the political leadership in many African countries saw a number of targeted university lecturers in Political Science and history leaving their countries for Europe and North America. Such tendencies delayed

the process of decolonising and Africanising the curriculum at African universities. These are some of the realities we have to contend with when embarking upon the tedious process of Africanising and decolonising the Political Science curriculum. But if this is a hurdle, it is one hurdle we cannot afford not to confront and win if the African continent is to regain its identity and respect.

Towards the decolonisation of a political science curriculum: lessons from East Africa

Already, some pointers have been given above. A few decades ago, the East African academic and political leadership argued that changing the curriculum is tantamount to moving the whole cemetery to a totally new venue (Mngomezulu 2012). This points to the mammoth task curriculum change entails, especially if such change is triggered by political factors or has political overtones. Within this context, it would be fair to aver that effecting curriculum changes in political science would not be an exception. One point that cannot be repudiated is that Africanising and decolonising the political science curriculum could prove to be a difficult assignment for various reasons. However, under no circumstances should that be seen to an insurmountable task; similar attempts have been made before.

Drawing from the East African experience, this section demonstrates how this goal could be achieved. We must re-state upfront that this does not dispute the fact that there were pre-colonial universities in Africa, nor does it undermine South African universities which are older than those of East Africa. As mentioned earlier, Mngomezulu (2004, 2012) covered that discussion at length, carving the entire continent. We deliberately decided to use the East African experience to demonstrate how African universities would go about in decolonising and Africanising the political science curriculum taking a cue from the East African experience in the 1960s and 1970s. This decision does not epitomise our being oblivious to the history of higher education in Africa in general and in South Africa in particular. Instead, our decision is informed by our understanding of how academics such as political scientist Ali Mazrui, historian Bethwell Ogot, politicians such as Presidents Julius Nyerere and Milton Obote took a vanguard position in terms of calling for the decolonisation and Africanisation of the university curriculum and showed in vivid terms how this goal could be achieved.

As the East African countries of Kenya, Uganda and Tanzania (following the merger of Tanganyika and Zanzibar in 1964) drew closer to obtaining independence from Britain, they started contemplating about how they would Africanise and decolonise their institutions. These institutions included the East Africa Legislative Assembly and the Federal University of East Africa which was established in 1963 and was subsequently dissolved in 1970. Our focus in this section will be on the latter, i.e. the federal university. We do not dwell much on the 1980s when national universities had taken over from the Federal University. This discussion is covered elsewhere (Sicherman 2005, 2008).

Soon after obtaining political independence from Britain between 1961 and 1963, these East African countries questioned the wisdom of having a regional federal university whose curriculum did not resonate with local situations. They called for the decolonisation and Africanisation of the curriculum. This call was embraced by different stakeholders. For instance, Hillary Ng'weno, one of the known journalists, asked a rhetorical question:

'transplant Oxford, Cambridge and Harvard with all their traditions and accentricities to the three East Africa capitals and what do you have?' (Daily Nation (Kenya), 23 April 1963).

According to East Africans, the decolonisation and Africaisation of the curriculum would be achieved by conducting research aimed at addressing local challenges in all spheres of life (Mazrui 1970; East African Standard (Kenya), 29 June 1963). President Nyerere's notion of African Socialism and his address at the inauguration of the Federal University in 1963 as its Chancellor stressed the need for the decolonisation and Africanisation of the curriculum. His proposals included calls for the use of African topics in Political Science, history and science subjects. He also impressed upon the need to study African political and governance systems. In response, the University Colleges in Nairobi, Dar es Salaam and Makerere moved towards a localised content. Even research methods leaned more towards orality so that local knowledge could be solicited from elder members of society. These attempts gave subjects like Political Science and history local flavour (Nyerere 1966; Ogot 2003).

A view was expressed that 'it is the duty of any university community to study, carry out research, publish and propagate all possible aspects of African art, culture, history and other subjects in the humanities instead of leaving these to people from abroad' (East Africa Journal, 1966, 35). Arthur Porter who was the Vice-Chancellor of the Federal University argued: 'May I expect that the Principal at Makerere University College will not continue to give us golden Shakespeare, golden Michaelangelo and golden Beethoven, but Rubadiri, Zirimu and Kakooza and other African writers, musicians, and artists?' (Porter 1972, 75). In fact, during the official launch of the federal University in 1963, President Nyerere did not mix his words. He stated categorically clear that the East African political and academic leadership could not afford a situation whereby they would beg for funds to run the university only to find that the university taught a foreign curriculum (Mngomezulu 2012).

Traditionally, Political Science books are written by Western scholars. Logically, they draw from their own home experience. In the process, African Political Science students are disadvantaged because they have to understand foreign concepts and try to make sense of examples drawn from elsewhere. East Africans conceded that Africa is very rich when it comes to Political Science topics and/or themes. They argued that state (and empire) formation is not a foreign concept in Africa. They made reference to well-known states such as Ghana, Mali and Songhay in West Africa. Indeed, governance and administration (which are critical concepts in Political Science) are not new in Africa (Khapoya 1998; Herbst 2000; Giblin 2005; Njoh 2006). This is the line of thought East Africans propagated.

Politics and economy are inextricably intertwined. Political Science cannot be divorced from a country's economy. Therefore, like East Africans, the Political Science curriculum could draw from the African experience and use examples from Africa as part of the Africanisation and decolonisation agenda of the Political Science curriculum. The African continent is replete with examples to show that in the realm of trade and commerce pre-colonial Africa was well positioned. There were towns and cities which made trade possible and boosted the economies of different regions across Africa (Hull 1976; King 1990; Coquery-Vidrovich 1991; Anderson and Rathbone 2000). It would be unfortunate for African and Africanist political scientists to continue privileging Western knowledge in the curriculum and writings when there are so many examples to draw from within Africa.

Political scientists have to educate society and shape public opinion. To achieve this goal, they use different platforms such as the media, academic journals, books, and public gatherings and formal lectures (Mngomezulu 2016). Given this power, political scientists have a major role to play in Africanising and decolonising the curriculum. Instead of showing over-reliance on theories and methodologies used in Europe and elsewhere, they should be able to promote the African ways of doing things. For example, they could emphasise *Ubuntu* both as an African philosophy and as a theoretical framework. This would force students to draw from the African paraphernalia instead of privileging Western inventions. Some postgraduate students in Political Science have already demonstrated that this is feasible (Selela 2015).

When writing books and academic papers, political scientists stand a better chance to decolonise the curriculum by conducting research using African-based examples. In turn, Political Science students who read their works would be introduced to a decolonised political science curriculum. This decolonisation project does not have to be pronounced all the time (important as that might be). Conversely, the decolonisation process should be seen as the outcome of what political scientists and other Africanists scholars do as common practice. In East Africa, political scientists and historians forged relations with the political leadership and pushed for the usage of local examples when teaching these two subjects. Academics such as the late Ali Mazrui, Bethwell Ogot and many others ensured that an Africanised curriculum took centre-stage in their teaching and research. They gave students research projects that would need oral sources and expected them to carry out these projects on weekends and during holidays. Through such mechanisms, local histories and local politics were captured in various research projects. Journal articles with local content were also published. Eventually, the university curriculum was Africanised and decolonised. Drawing from this East African experience, it is clear that indeed the decolonisation and Africanisation of the political science curriculum is not a far-fetched dream.

But as East Africans faced challenges in their Africanisation and decolonisation agenda, other Africans are bound to face some challenges – even if these are different from those faced by the East African academic and political leadership.

Conclusion

In conclusion, it is an indubitable fact that the curriculum constitutes the core of any subject. No matter how important or relevant a subject might be, if its curriculum is not cogently thought through, the value of that subject is diminished. Political Science is one of the most valuable subjects in any country. African countries are no exception in this regard. But for this subject to achieve its intended goal, it has to be relevant to the local environment.

In this article, we have consistently argued why it is important to Africanise and decolonise the Political Science curriculum. We stated that pre-colonial Africans made a significant contribution to world civilisation. Secondly, we argued that their contribution was eroded by both Christianity and colonialism. As such, throughout the colonial era Western knowledge systems took centre-stage while African knowledge systems were completely obliterated. Our key argument is that in the post-colonial and post-Apartheid era African universities have a responsibility to decolonise and Africanise the university

curriculum in general and the Political Science curriculum in particular. As Mbembe (2015) and other Africanist scholars remind us, we cannot keep teaching in the same manner we have always taught during the colonial era and still claim to be free. Political freedom should also mean freedom of thought. The notion of power as discussed above is critical in this regard.

Lastly, a post-colonial curriculum should reflect a changed political climate. It is here where the energy should be invested. To achieve this goal, we draw from the East African experience and make practical suggestions as to how this could be done in practice. We do this being mindful of the fact that similar examples could be drawn elsewhere. Our conclusion is that decolonising and Africanising the Political Science curriculum is possible provided that there is the political will to do so. Our view is that this should not be the job of one stakeholder; it needs concerted effort by everyone, including the political leadership, academic leadership and the Political Science students who will be the beneficiaries of a decolonised and an Africanised university curriculum. Africans should be the custodians of their own knowledge system. There is no better place to generate and preserve such knowledge than through curriculum reform.

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